The shooting started before the column had moved more than half a mile. Mackenzie's party quickly got separated from the jezailchis who had led the retreat, and he found himself alone and under fire, 'with a chaprasi and two sowars in the midst of the wailing crowd of women and children'. Soon after this he was surrounded. At first he thought it was his own men, but 'they quickly undeceived me by crying out "Feringhee hast" (Here is a European) and attacking me with swords and knives.' Mackenzie spurred his horse and wheeled round,

> cutting from right to left. My blows, by God's mercy, parried the greater part of theirs, and I was lucky enough to cut off the hand of my most outrageous assailant. My sword went clean through the man's arm, but just after that, I received such a tremendous blow on the back of the head that, though the sabre turned in my enemy's hand, it knocked me almost off my horse. Hanging on with one foot . . . the next thing I remember was finding myself upright in the saddle in advance of the enemy, with the whole picket firing after me. I passed unhurt through two volleys of musketry. The picket pursued, but I soon distanced them, crossing several fields at speed . . . Proceeding cautiously along, I found to my horror my path again blocked up by a dense body of Afghans. Retreat was impossible, so, putting my trust in God, I charged into the midst of them, hoping that the weight of the horse would clear the way for me, and reserving my sword-cut for the last struggle. It was well that I did so, for by the time I had knocked over a heap of fellows, I found that they were my own Jezailchis.

Eventually they reached the cantonment. 'During the night,' noted Mackenzie, 'many stragglers of my party, principally followers, dropped in. From first to last I had about a dozen killed. Among the errors which led to our downfall, that of omitting to strengthen my post was the worst. Every Afghan of intelligence has confessed that if I had been reinforced by a couple of regiments, we should have remained masters of the city.'[51]

Hugh Johnson, already aghast at the folly of the generals in allowing his treasury to fall into the hands of the rebels, was even more horrified at the loss of all food supplies – and all this within only thirty-six hours of the outbreak of the revolt. 'Four lakh of rupees worth of wheat, barley, wine, beer & every requisite were surrendered without a blow being struck back to our enemy,' he wrote in his diary the following day.

> Numbers of people, and especially that large and influential tribe the Qizilbashes, had hitherto kept aloof from the struggle, and much as they might have been astonished at our inactivity for a day or two, and our apparent apathy at the loss of our Treasury and the murder of our Resident, it never entered their most idle dreams that a British force of five thousand men of whose high state of discipline & courage and of the wisdom of their leaders they had always